

Gathered-bust empire mini dress

EU38 sewing guide . 9 pieces . 2 m fabric at 140 cm

text-first guide, no illustrations in this edition. Every step is the engine's own instruction.

Cut list

Bodice Front - cut 1 on fold

Bodice Center Back - cut 2

Bodice Side Back - cut 2

Skirt Front - cut 1 on fold

Skirt Back - cut 2 (center back seam)

Waist Tie (bel ba 1) - cut 2 rectangle(s) 90 x 630 mm (finished 30 x 600 mm), each ties from the side seam round to a bow at center

Shirred Bust Panel (büzgübüst panosu) - cut 1 rectangle(s) 881 x 140 mm (join to a 851 mm flat top edge that gathers down to 400 mm)

Steps

1. Print and check the 3 cm calibration square before cutting.
2. This block uses standard assumptions for shoulder slope, underbust - sew a quick muslin (test version) from cheap fabric first and adjust before cutting your real fabric.
3. Cut every piece as labelled: pieces marked 'on fold' on the fabric fold, 'cut 2' twice.
4. Staystitch the neckline just inside the seam line so it doesn't stretch while you work.
5. Staystitch the curved princess edges too, for the same reason.
6. Sew each bodice princess seam: pin center panel to side panel matching the bust notch, sew, clip the side panel's curve over the bust inside the seam allowance, press toward the center.
7. Sew the remaining waist darts (where a panel wasn't split), pressing toward the center.
8. Sew the bodice shoulder seams and press them open.
9. Prepare the neckline bias strip: join the ends as needed and press it in half lengthwise along the marked fold line.
10. Bind the neckline with the bias strip, right sides together and raw edges even, leaving the last 2 cm free at each center back edge (the zipper goes there later). Ease the strip gently around the curves. Trim to 6 mm, turn the folded edge to the inside and topstitch or slipstitch it down.
11. Sew the bodice side seams.
12. Finish each armhole the same way with its bias strip: press it in half, bind the armhole right sides together, ease around the curve, then turn and topstitch it to the inside.
13. Gather the skirt panels along the marked line until they match the bodice waist.

14. Sew the skirt seams (leave the center back seam open where the zipper will go), then join bodice to skirt at the underbust seam (the empire line sits right under the bust), matching side seams and lining the gore seams up with the bodice princess seams as closely as possible.
15. Insert an invisible zipper in the center back through bodice and skirt: install the zipper BEFORE closing the seam below it, then close the rest of the seam.
16. Fold the free binding ends back over the zipper tape and hand-tack them down so the edge sits clean against the zipper.
17. Try it on, then hem with a 2 cm double fold.
18. Ties (ba): cut the tie rectangle(s) as labelled, fold each in half lengthwise right sides together, stitch the long edge and one short end, turn right side out and press. Stitch the raw end to the marked placement notch (right sides together, caught in the seam), then knot into a bow. The tie is self-fabric cut on the straight grain.
19. Shirred gathering (büzgü): cut the panel. Wind elastic thread on the bobbin and sew along each marked shirring row (right side up); the elastic pulls the panel down to about half its flat width (2:1) as you sew the rows. Steam to tighten. Join the gathered edge to the body at the placement notch, matching the finished length.